

THE EMPEROR WHO WOULD NOT KNEEL

Chapter 6 — “The Infernal Bargain”

Format: Traditional right-to-left manga script. Read panels right-to-left, top-to-bottom.

Black-and-white. Heavy ink shadow, cinematic negative space, screentone.

Approx. 38 pages.

PAGE 1

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (wide, full-width top — continuing directly from Ch.5)

The heavenly host does NOT descend. Not yet. They remain suspended in the torn sky above the Wastes — hundreds of white shapes outlined by fire, spears pointed downward, wings motionless. No dialogue.

Panel 2 (narrow, the camp waits)

The camp beneath them waits. No one speaks. The dead stand in their ragged line behind Egris. No dialogue.

Panel 3

The woman in red holds the boy's hand so tightly his fingers have gone pale. The two brothers stand near one another, not looking at each other. BORCHU grips broken stone like a club. No dialogue.

PAGE 2

Panels: 4

Panel 1

A young soldier with a split breastplate holds his sword in both hands. His knuckles TREMBLE. No dialogue.

Panel 2

EGRIS stands at the front with his cracked spear. No dialogue.

Panel 3

Across from him, SERAPHEL watches in silence, burning sword still raised. No dialogue.

Panel 4

SERAPHEL: “You have made your decision.”

PAGE 3

Panels: 3

Panel 1

EGRIS: "No. They have."

Panel 2

SERAPHEL looks past him at the gathered souls.

SERAPHEL: "They do not understand what waits for them."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "Neither do you."

PAGE 4

Panels: 2 (silent — dread building)

Panel 1 (wide — a tremor passes through the air)

Not from the heavens. From BENEATH the ground.

SFX: ...rmmmmble...

Panel 2

The ash at Egris's feet shifts.

SFX: sssssh

PAGE 5

Panels: 3

Panel 1

The pale light above them FLICKERS.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

Every angel in the sky turns at once — away from Egris, toward something else.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

Close on SERAPHEL's face — for the first time, something close to UNCERTAINTY.

No dialogue.

PAGE 6

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — page-turn reveal)

A BLACK LINE opens across the far horizon. It begins beneath the broken ruins where the Hollow Men had emerged. At first, no wider than a sword cut in the earth. Then it SPREADS outward, splitting stone, swallowing ash.

A sound rises from it: LAUGHTER. Not loud. Worse than that. The sound of someone enjoying a thing before it has even happened.

SFX (deep, layered): hehehehe...hahahaha...

PAGE 7

Panels: 3

Panel 1

The angels' white fire DIMS as darkness pours from the crack — rolling low across the Wastes like smoke, but it does not rise. It crawls.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

Wherever it touches, the ruins CHANGE. Stone becomes black glass. Ash becomes red sand.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

The cold air becomes thick with heat. The dead behind Egris begin to COUGH, though none need breath.

SFX (coughing, scattered)

PAGE 8

Panels: 3

Panel 1

SERAPHEL lowers his blade.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

EGRIS, flat.

EGRIS: "This does not concern you."

Panel 3

SERAPHEL's gaze remains fixed on the spreading darkness.

SERAPHEL: "It concerns all who remain in this realm."

PAGE 9

Panels: 3

Panel 1

EGRIS: "Then perhaps Heaven should have arrived sooner."

Panel 2

SERAPHEL looks at him sharply.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

Before he can answer, the black line in the earth SPLITS OPEN.

SFX: KRA-KOOM

PAGE 10**Panels: 2****Panel 1** (large, top — figures climb out)

They wear armor made from fused bone and iron. Helmets with no eyeholes. Red fire burns in narrow gaps around their mouths. Some carry hooked chains. Others axes that drip smoke onto the ground. No dialogue.

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

They march in FORMATION. Unlike the frightened dead behind Egris, they move as one body. No hesitation. No fear. No choice. No dialogue.

PAGE 11**Panels: 1** (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — the STRANGER arrives)

At the center of the infernal soldiers walks a MAN Egris recognizes. He wears no armor — only a dark robe bound at the waist by braided leather. Hair cut close to his head. A scar runs from the corner of his mouth to his left ear. He carries a curved sword in one hand, its edge shining red.

EGRIS's face: recognition. Old, cold recognition.

PAGE 12**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

BORCHU sees Egris's expression.
BORCHU: "You know him?"

Panel 2

EGRIS does not answer.
No dialogue.

Panel 3

The STRANGER continues forward until he stands between the infernal soldiers and Seraphel. He looks at the angel first. Then he SMILES.
No dialogue.

PAGE 13**Panels: 3**

Panel 1

STRANGER: "Well. They truly did send an angel."

Panel 2

SERAPHEL, voice hard.

SERAPHEL: "You do not belong here, demon."

Panel 3

The STRANGER spreads his arms slightly.

STRANGER: "Neither does he."

PAGE 14**Panels: 2****Panel 1**

His eyes settle on EGRIS.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (wide — a memory flash, screentoned/ghosted)

For a moment, the Wastes disappear. Egris sees another place: a field beneath a burning sky. Men shouting. Horses screaming. A camp of torn tents. The same face, younger, holding a sword wet with blood.

NARRATION (box): He remembered the betrayal.

PAGE 15**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

EGRIS, cold.

EGRIS: "You are dead."

Panel 2

The STRANGER gives a small bow.

STRANGER: "So are you."

Panel 3

The dead behind Egris shift uneasily. The young soldier lowers his sword a fraction. Borchu studies the stranger with narrowed eyes.

No dialogue.

PAGE 16**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

BORCHU: "Who is he?"

Panel 2

EGRIS's jaw tightens.

EGRIS: "Someone who thought a throne mattered more than loyalty."

Panel 3

The STRANGER laughs.

SFX: heh

PAGE 17**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

STRANGER: "And there he is."

Panel 2

He walks closer. The infernal soldiers behind him stop at the edge of the darkened ground, standing perfectly still.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

STRANGER: "You still speak as if you were betrayed. As if you were innocent."

PAGE 18**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

EGRIS: "You swore an oath."

Panel 2

STRANGER: "I swore an oath to a leader who had not yet decided the world belonged to him."

Panel 3

EGRIS says nothing.

No dialogue.

Panel 4

The stranger's smile fades.

No dialogue.

PAGE 19**Panels: 2****Panel 1**

STRANGER: "You conquered until no man could stand beside you without living in your shadow. You demanded unity, but you meant obedience."

Panel 2

STRANGER: "You spoke of brotherhood, then judged every brother by whether he served your ambition."

PAGE 20**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

The words strike close. Too close.

NARRATION (box): The words struck close.

Panel 2

EGRIS lifts his spear.

EGRIS: "Say why you are here."

Panel 3

The stranger's expression brightens again.

STRANGER: "Straight to the point. Good. Death has not softened you."

PAGE 21**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

EGRIS: "No."

Panel 2

STRANGER: "It has not softened me either."

Panel 3

He turns toward the camp. The frightened souls watch him like prey sensing a predator.

No dialogue.

Panel 4

STRANGER: "This is what you have now? A child. A grieving woman. Men too frightened to hold their weapons properly."

PAGE 22**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

The young soldier's grip TIGHTENS on his sword.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

EGRIS takes one step forward.

EGRIS: "You will not speak of them again."

Panel 3

The stranger's smile widens.

STRANGER: "There. That is why he chose you."

Panel 4

EGRIS: "Who?"

PAGE 23**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

The stranger looks up toward the heavens.

STRANGER: "Not Him."

Panel 2

Then he looks down toward the fissure in the earth.

STRANGER: "Not whatever waits below, either."

Panel 3

His gaze returns to Egris.

STRANGER: "The one who understands what you are."

Panel 4 (wide — the black crack widens)

SFX: KRRRK

PAGE 24**Panels: 2****Panel 1**

A VOICE comes from the darkness. Soft. Warm. Almost kind.

VOICE: "Egris."

Panel 2 (wide — the name moves through him like fire)

The dead CRY OUT. Several fall to their knees. The boy covers his ears. The woman pulls him against her chest. Borchu remains standing, but color drains from his face.

No dialogue.

PAGE 25**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

SERAPHEL raises his sword again.

SERAPHEL: "Do not listen."

Panel 2

EGRIS does not take his eyes from the darkness.

EGRIS: "I was not speaking to you."

Panel 3

The voice CHUCKLES.

VOICE: "You have always been speaking to me."

PAGE 26

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — SATAN's hand emerges)

A HAND reaches out from the dark. Beautiful at first glance — pale skin, long fingers, a ring of black metal on every joint.

Then Egris sees: the hand has TOO MANY FINGERS. And each ring bears the face of someone SCREAMING.

PAGE 27

Panels: 3

Panel 1

The STRANGER in the dark robe lowers his head. Not in worship. In acknowledgment.
No dialogue.

Panel 2

BORCHU whispers.

BORCHU: "Satan."

Panel 3

The word spreads through the camp. Some souls pray. Others back away.
No dialogue.

PAGE 28

Panels: 3

Panel 1

The VOICE from the darkness: "Do not call me by names others gave me. They only name what they fear."

Panel 2

EGRIS looks at the hand extending from the crack.

EGRIS: "You sent him."

Panel 3

VOICE: "I sent an opportunity."

PAGE 29

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS: "I have had enough of those."

Panel 2

VOICE: "No. You have had commands dressed as gifts."

Panel 3

The black hand OPENS.

No dialogue.

Panel 4 (close detail — the iron crown)

Resting in its palm: a small IRON CROWN. No jewels, no light, no symbols. Plain. Scarred. Heavy-looking. Made for war.

No dialogue.

PAGE 30**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

VOICE: "Heaven offers you a place. I offer you a choice."

Panel 2

SERAPHEL steps forward.

SERAPHEL: "His choices always come with chains."

Panel 3

The voice LAUGHS.

VOICE: "And yours come with kneeling."

PAGE 31**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

SERAPHEL's sword FLASHES. A line of white fire cuts through the air toward the fissure.

SFX: SHNNNG

Panel 2

The darkness SWALLOWS it. No explosion. No impact. The light simply disappears.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

SERAPHEL stares at the empty space where it had been.

No dialogue.

PAGE 32**Panels: 2**

Panel 1

SATAN's hand remains extended toward Egris.

VOICE: "Take it. The Wastes are filled with those Heaven abandoned."

Panel 2

VOICE: "Give them banners. Give them weapons. Give them enemies. I will give you an army that never doubts, never fears, and never asks whether your cause is worth dying for."

PAGE 33**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

EGRIS looks at the crown.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

Then at the infernal soldiers. They stand in perfect discipline. They look like an army.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

NARRATION (box): But Egris had known armies. He had known the sound of men whispering before battle. He had seen fear in their eyes, courage in spite of it. These creatures carried none of that. They were weapons waiting to be used.

PAGE 34**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

EGRIS: "And what do you take in return?"

Panel 2

SATAN's fingers curl slightly around the crown.

VOICE: "Nothing you do not already desire."

Panel 3

The STRANGER beside the fissure laughs under his breath.

No dialogue.

PAGE 35**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

EGRIS turns toward the stranger.

EGRIS: "You believe that?"

Panel 2

STRANGER: "I know it."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "Then tell me."

Panel 4

The man's scar pulls tight as his smile vanishes.

STRANGER: "Vengeance."

PAGE 36**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

The word comes quietly. But it cuts deeper than shouting.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

STRANGER: "Take his army. Build your empire. Tear Heaven's gates down. Make every god understand what it means to be powerless."

Panel 3

STRANGER: "And when you are done, give me the men who betrayed me."

PAGE 37**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

EGRIS stares at him.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

BORCHU mutters behind him.

BORCHU: "There it is. The price."

Panel 3

The STRANGER's eyes flash.

STRANGER: "You have no right to speak."

PAGE 38**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

BORCHU answers.

BORCHU: "I have every right. You came asking another man to spend blood for your wound."

Panel 2

The stranger takes a step toward him. Infernal fire moves along the edge of his sword.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS places himself between them.
No dialogue.

Panel 4

EGRIS: "You do not approach my people."

PAGE 39**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

STRANGER: "Your people? You said they were not yours."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "They are under my protection."

Panel 3 (wide — the words leave him before he can consider them)

The camp falls QUIET. The woman in red looks at him. So does the young soldier. Even Seraphel's expression changes.
No dialogue.

PAGE 40**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

The STRANGER gives a slow, mocking nod.

STRANGER: "Protection becomes command. Command becomes ownership. You know this. You have always known it."

Panel 2

EGRIS looks at the dead behind him. At their fear. At their uncertainty. At the fragile courage they found together.
No dialogue.

Panel 3

Then he looks back at the offered crown.
No dialogue.

PAGE 41**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

SATAN's voice softens.

VOICE: "You fear becoming a tyrant."

Panel 2

EGRIS says nothing.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

VOICE: "Good. Fear is wisdom, when it is honest. But do not confuse hesitation with virtue."

PAGE 42**Panels: 2****Panel 1**

VOICE: "You cannot shelter them with a broken spear. You cannot defend them from Heaven with brave words."

Panel 2

VOICE: "You cannot build a kingdom from the dead without making choices that cost someone something."

PAGE 43**Panels: 2****Panel 1**

The hand moves closer. The iron crown waits in its palm.

VOICE: "Take it."

Panel 2 (wide — the young soldier steps forward)

His face has gone pale.

SOLDIER: "Egris."

PAGE 44**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

EGRIS does not look back.

EGRIS: "What?"

Panel 2

The young soldier, terrified but asking anyway.

SOLDIER: "If you take it...will we have to obey you?"

Panel 3 (wide, silent — the question stops everything)

The angels remain in the air. The demons wait beside the fissure. The stranger watches with hard, hungry eyes.

No dialogue.

PAGE 45

Panels: 3

Panel 1

EGRIS looks at the boy — no, not a boy. A soldier. Frightened and broken, but **STANDING**.
No dialogue.

Panel 2

EGRIS has no answer ready. That frightens him more than Heaven's army.
No dialogue.

Panel 3

Finally, he says:
EGRIS: "No."

PAGE 46

Panels: 4

Panel 1

SATAN's fingers go **STILL**.
No dialogue.

Panel 2

EGRIS continues.
EGRIS: "You will not kneel to me. You will not worship me. You will not fight because I demand it."

Panel 3

The young soldier swallows.
SOLDIER: "Then why should we stay?"

Panel 4

EGRIS: "Because you choose to."

PAGE 47

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (wide, heavy silence)
The camp is silent.
No dialogue.

Panel 2

EGRIS turns to the darkness.
EGRIS: "And I will not take a crown from someone who believes every soul can be bought."

PAGE 48

Panels: 3

Panel 1

The hand CLOSES around the iron crown.
No dialogue.

Panel 2

For the first time, the warmth leaves Satan's voice.
VOICE: "Be careful, Emperor."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "I am not an emperor."

PAGE 49**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

VOICE: "Not yet."

Panel 2

The fissure SHAKES. The infernal soldiers raise their weapons. Seraphel lifts his sword in answer.
SFX: RMMMMBLE

Panel 3

For one terrible moment, Egris believes Heaven and Hell will fall upon the camp together.
No dialogue.

PAGE 50**Panels: 2****Panel 1**

Then SATAN LAUGHS.
VOICE: "Another time."

Panel 2 (wide — the darkness begins to withdraw)

The infernal soldiers step backward into the crack, one by one, never breaking formation.
No dialogue.

PAGE 51**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

The STRANGER remains until the last of them has vanished. He looks at Egris with hatred that has survived death.
STRANGER: "You always choose the harder path."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "No. I choose my own."

Panel 3

The stranger's mouth tightens. Then he steps backward into the darkness.
No dialogue.

PAGE 52**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

The fissure CLOSES. The red sand turns back to ash. The heat fades.
SFX: ...ssshhh...

Panel 2

Above them, Heaven's host still hangs in the torn sky.
No dialogue.

Panel 3

SERAPHEL looks down at Egris.
SERAPHEL: "You have refused both thrones."

PAGE 53**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

EGRIS: "They were never mine to accept."

Panel 2

SERAPHEL: "You believe refusing power makes you different from those who seek it."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "No. I believe refusing to be owned does."

Panel 4

For a long moment, Seraphel says nothing.
No dialogue.

PAGE 54**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

Then the angel SHEATHES his sword.
SFX: shnk

Panel 2

The white lines above the Wastes begin to CLOSE. The heavenly soldiers rise with them, carried upward into thinning light.
No dialogue.

Panel 3

SERAPHEL: "You will be given no further warning."

PAGE 55**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

EGRIS: "I did not ask for one."

Panel 2

The angel's gaze moves across the gathered souls. Then, unexpectedly, he looks at the young soldier with the split breastplate.

SERAPHEL: "Choose carefully."

Panel 3

The soldier meets his eyes. After a moment, he answers:

SOLDIER: "I did."

PAGE 56**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

SERAPHEL's expression becomes unreadable.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

Then he vanishes into the light.

SFX: fwssh

Panel 3

The sky seals itself.

No dialogue.

PAGE 57**Panels: 2****Panel 1** (wide — darkness returns to the Wastes)

Not the darkness of Hell. Not the darkness of death. Only the vast, waiting dark of a land that belongs to no one.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

For several breaths, no one moves.

No dialogue.

PAGE 58

Panels: 3

Panel 1

Then, from the edge of the camp, a NEW VOICE speaks. Calm. Male. Old enough to have learned patience.

VOICE: "You refused Heaven and Hell in the same day."

Panel 2

EGRIS turns.

No dialogue.

Panel 3 (wide — SURO sits atop a slab of fallen stone near the ruined road)

A man in a long coat of dark, weathered cloth, fastened high at the throat. A narrow sword rests across his knees — plain sheath, faded leather-wrapped handle. His eyes are covered by a strip of black cloth. Ash has gathered along his shoulders. He has been there long enough.

No one noticed him.

No dialogue.

PAGE 59

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS studies the sword first. Then the blindfold.

EGRIS: "You were watching."

Panel 2

SURO: "I was listening."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "Why?"

Panel 4

SURO tilts his head toward the camp.

SURO: "Because people become loud when gods arrive."

PAGE 60

Panels: 3

Panel 1

BORCHU lifts his broken weapon.

BORCHU: "Who are you?"

Panel 2

The stranger's mouth twitches — not quite a smile.

SURO: "A man who has followed kings before."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "And?"

PAGE 61

Panels: 3

Panel 1

SURO: "And I have buried what they left behind."

Panel 2

He STANDS. His movements are careful but certain. He does not reach for the stone or test the ground. He seems to know exactly where he is.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

The blind swordsman turns his covered eyes toward Egris.

SURO: "You refused an army. That was either wisdom or foolishness."

PAGE 62

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS: "Which?"

Panel 2

SURO: "I have not decided."

Panel 3

EGRIS rests both hands on his spear.

EGRIS: "And why should I care what you decide?"

Panel 4

SURO's fingers settle on the hilt of his blade.

SURO: "Because what comes next will be louder than gods."

PAGE 63

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — closing image)

Pull back wide. The camp small against the vast Wastes. EGRIS and SURO facing one another across the cracked ground. BORCHU and the souls watching. The ruins dark behind them. The pale empty sky above.

Somewhere in the darkness beyond, something ancient has heard Egris refuse both Heaven and Hell.

And it is waiting to see what he will become.

NARRATION (box, lower corner): For the first time since the heavens had opened, Egris felt the old gaze watching from beyond the Wastes. Quiet. Patient. Ancient.

— END OF CHAPTER 6 —

SCRIPT NOTES (for artist / letterer)

- **Reading direction:** Right-to-left. Panel 1 sits at top-right of every page.
- **This chapter balances three powers:** Heaven (still hovering above), Hell (arriving from below), and Egris (refusing both). Frame the visual composition to show him caught between two enormous forces — and choosing NEITHER.
- **Page 26 splash (Satan's hand)** is body-horror. The too-many fingers and screaming-face rings must be clearly drawn and deeply unsettling.
- **The Stranger's design:** scar from mouth to ear (always visible), dark robe, curved red-edged sword. He is NOT a demon — he is a dead man who made a deal. Draw him as human, bitter, and dangerous.
- **The young soldier's question (Page 44)** is the chapter's emotional fulcrum. Give it a full beat of silence before Egris answers.
- **Page 58 (Suro's reveal)** — he has been there the WHOLE TIME, unnoticed. Place him in a spot that makes sense retroactively (edge of camp, away from the main action, still, silent). Ash on his shoulders = he's been sitting there for hours.
- **Suro's design:** long dark weathered coat, black blindfold, plain sword, lean build. His stillness is eerie — he doesn't test the ground, doesn't fumble. He KNOWS where everything is without seeing.
- **Tone:** This chapter is exhausting for everyone — two refusals back-to-back, Egris's first true claim of "my people," and then a new unknown (Suro) arriving just as they thought it was over.